for legislators—83 percent of them surveyed after the war did not want India to side with either the US and its allies or the Soviet Union and its allies.[106] Shashi Tharoor has observed that over the years, Nehru had conveyed his government's foreign policy not as his or that of the Congress Party, but as the country's foreign policy. Moreover, he had "transform[ed] opposition to its fundamentals into opposition to India's very independence."[107]

This transformation ended up tying Nehru's own hands in some ways as well—ironic for an approach that was designed to expand Indian policymakers' options. Even those who had earlier criticized nonalignment exploited any perceived departure from it to criticize the government. This was perhaps most visible in the reaction to the possibility that the US would set up a Voice of America transmitter in eastern India. Delhi had agreed to such a proposal in early 1963, partly because the plan helped India, given that it was designed to transmit anticommunist propaganda into China. When the news broke that summer, however, broad criticism that it was a violation of nonalignment led the government to repudiate the agreement.[108] The Indian government also downplayed the November air defense exercise, put off a second one, and denied in parliament that foreign militaries would be involved in the defense of India.[109]

Tethered, but Not Tied (December 1963–April 1965)

Narratives of US-India relations in the Lyndon Johnson era have tended to focus on the countries' "divergent interests."[110] But during this period, there was at least one major subject of agreement between Indian and US policymakers: that China was the main threat in Asia. As McMahon has noted, for American policymakers, China "had become a near-demonic force in world affairs."[111] As Vietnam became Johnson's primary foreign policy preoccupation, he became increasingly concerned about Chinese bellicosity and its support for Ho Chi Minh. He perceived the North Vietnamese leader's actions both as a nationalist struggle and as part of a "much more ambitious strategy" from the communist bloc.[112] And, to protect American security and credibility, it was crucial to prevent losses to that bloc.